PlantCircle

Global Product Strategy & Business Plan

Working name: PlantCircle (subject to trademark, domain and app-store clearance)
Document: Founder strategy, go-to-market and commercial blueprint
Version: 1.0 | **Date:** 31 October 2026 | **Status:** Proposed, research-led, not yet market validated
Platforms: Native-feeling iOS and Android apps through a shared cross-platform codebase; supporting web-based organizer administration and discovery

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Executive decision

Build a global, mobile-first community operating through strong local chapters. PlantCircle brings vegans, vegetarians and people exploring plant-based living together to form friendships, teach and learn, organize cooking experiences and community activities, support one another, and coordinate collective purchasing. It is not primarily a restaurant directory, recipe database, dating app, generic feed, or Europe-only product.

Core promise: *Find your people. Learn together. Make plans happen.*

Proposed wedge: an end-to-end **Community Plan**, which turns a shared interest into an organized, safe, attended activity and a continuing relationship. A Plan can be a potluck, cooking workshop, walking group, community dinner, online learning session, volunteer activity, or collaborative grocery purchase. Circles organize recurring relationships; knowledge posts and lessons keep communities valuable between activities.

Strategic principle: global discoverability does not mean simultaneous marketing spend everywhere. Build a globally capable product from launch and concentrate host recruitment in a handful of pilot cities spanning Africa, the Americas, and (subsequently) Europe and Asia. Each chapter needs enough events and trusted hosts to create a functioning local network. Users outside pilot cities can participate in worldwide online Circles and propose the next local chapter.

Decision gates: no large paid acquisition until repeat participation is demonstrated; no platform-handled group-order payments in MVP; no promise of guaranteed vegan ingredient safety; no launch without staffed reporting and moderation.

1. The customer problem

People following plant-based diets are connected to content but not necessarily to one another in practical daily life. A person can browse thousands of recipes yet struggle to find a nearby cooking buddy, reliable in-person events, an affordable group order, or culturally relevant cooking guidance. Existing social tools split a single journey across Instagram, WhatsApp, Facebook, Meetup, spreadsheets, and payment links.

The opportunity is therefore **coordination and belonging**, not merely information discovery. Key jobs to be done:

1. **Belong:** “Help me meet people who share my interests and respect my food choices, without forcing me into dating or activism.”

2. **Learn:** “Help me learn practical, affordable, culturally relevant cooking and lifestyle skills from other members.”
3. **Act:** “Help us organize and reliably attend group activities instead of endless chat planning.”
4. **Share resources:** “Help nearby people coordinate bulk ingredient purchases, swaps and shared preparation safely.”
5. **Stay connected:** “Help worthwhile connections become recurring groups and friendships after an event.”
6. **Discover globally:** “Let me learn from communities in other countries while prioritizing useful local experiences.”

These are plausible problems, not yet quantified demand. Research must determine frequency, willingness to switch from existing channels, and willingness to pay.

2. Evidence, competition and market hypotheses

2.1 Verified ecosystem indicators

- VGN Social says it launched in August 2025 on iOS and Android and already offers local vegan friends, events and places. It is a direct competitor, not merely a website. [S1]
- All My Vegans lists German community groups, meetups, recipes and social features on Google Play. [S2]
- HappyCow reports more than 1.52 million registered members as of 31 October 2026, though its main job is place discovery. This is evidence of product demand for vegan-oriented tools, **not** PlantCircle's addressable community audience. [S3]
- Nigeria has an active ProVeg country program; the East African Vegan Society explicitly aims to connect the region's movement; and Thrive Africa Vegan Restaurant Week reports campaigns across several African countries. [S4] [S5] [S6]
- Brazil has the Sociedade Vegetariana Brasileira and organized local chapters; VegFest Brasil 2026 advertises a major multi-day event. [S7] [S8]

Interpretation: the movement has organizations, members and events worldwide. We do not have proof that existing community products have poor engineering, low retention or weak monetization. Compete through observed user outcomes and execution, not assumptions about other teams' technology.

2.2 Competitive jobs, not only competitor logos

Alternative	User gets today	PlantCircle must outperform it on
WhatsApp / Telegram groups	Close-knit local group chat	Discoverability, searchable Plans, RSVP limits, structured coordination, trust, persistent community identity
Instagram / TikTok	Recipes, creators, inspiration	Collaboration, localized groups, participant management and recurring relationships
Facebook Groups / Meetup	Communities and event listings	A unified host-to-attendee mobile experience for small recurring activities and collaborative tasks
VGN Social	Vegan connections, events and places	Cultural cooking exchanges, Plan logistics, teaching workflows and group orders
All My Vegans / other social apps	Groups, recipes, events	Demonstrated city-by-city activity completion and host success rather than feature count

Alternative	User gets today	PlantCircle must outperform it on
HappyCow	Vegan-friendly place discovery	Organizing activities with people rather than listing venues
Community NGOs and festivals	Existing trust and offline audiences	Useful member tools and partnerships rather than replacing local organizers

2.3 Distinctive product thesis

- **Activity-first graph:** connect people through doing, not popularity feeds.
- **One global network, many local chapters:** follow global knowledge and join city-based activities without exposing precise home location.
- **Culturally grounded participation:** support African, Asian, Latin American, European and Middle Eastern plant-based foods, budgets and local customs—not a narrow Western food catalogue.
- **Organizer operating system:** templates for invitations, RSVP/waitlists, dish contributions, ingredient quantities, reminders and post-event continuity.
- **Collective action:** start with low-risk coordination of community bulk purchases and food swaps, then validate regulated commerce where useful.
- **Trust-by-design:** verified organizers where warranted, moderation, anti-harassment controls, attendee privacy, safe location-release rules and accountable host processes.

These differentiators are hypotheses that require side-by-side user testing against existing workflows.

3. Market segmentation and regional strategy

3.1 Members to serve

Segment	Core need	Strongest activity	Monetization sensitivity
Committed vegans	Values-aligned friendship and accurate food practices	Local Circles, potlucks, verified vegan-only events	Free social core, optional experiences
Vegetarians	Belonging without gatekeeping, cooking variety	Interest Circles and workshops	Price-sensitive, event-based
Plant-curious / flexitarians	Practical guidance without judgment	Beginner lessons, mentor Circles, low-cost cooking	Low friction essential
Relocating people / travelers	Find community in new city	Meetups and city introductions	Medium, may buy experiences
Students / budget-conscious members	Affordable ingredients and company	Co-orders, cooking and campus events	High price sensitivity
Hosts / chefs / organizers	Fill events, manage attendees, build recurring followings	Host tools, workshops, participant coordination	B2B-style subscription and event fees
Community partners / nonprofits	Organize and reach members	Chapter management, event publishing	Sponsorship or negotiated tools

Participation policy: inclusive to all self-described diets; members can join general Circles without declaring a diet identity. Event-specific rules can require vegan food or allergen labeling while respecting members' privacy. No user is forced to publish personal beliefs.

3.2 Global launch architecture, dense local execution

Global technical reach: supported countries with app-store distribution, user account creation, online learning Circles, timezone-aware events, international content discovery and language preferences. Region-specific paid services and local events must remain gated until compliance and operations are ready.

Proposed pilot slate, to be validated:

City / region	Why test	Launch dependencies
Lagos, Nigeria	African cultural-food content; large creator and student communities; potential local organizer partners	8-12 committed organizers; local moderation; low-data Android testing
Nairobi, Kenya	East African community partners, cooking culture and mobile-money relevance	6-10 organizers; English plus multilingual content; local safety playbook
New York City, USA	Dense event and creator ecosystem, international audience	8-12 organizers; differentiated Plan experience; US legal and payment review
São Paulo, Brazil	Brazilian vegetarian associations and major plant-based events	Portuguese localization, local chapter leads, organizer partnerships

Wave 2 candidates: Berlin/London, Toronto, Mexico City, Johannesburg/Cape Town, Paris, Mumbai and Sydney—selected by demonstrated host supply, community requests and local compliance, not just population. There is no assumption that the four pilots are equally attractive; prelaunch research can swap them.

Launch 2 pilot cities with excellent supply before expanding to 4. A global user can always join cross-border online activities; their home city is optional and can be manually selected. Avoid collecting precise GPS coordinates unless the user requests a nearby feature.

3.3 Localization model

Day-one product locales: English and Brazilian Portuguese if São Paulo is in the first pilots. Add German, Spanish, French and Swahili based on chapter readiness and demand. Allow user-created content in any language, Unicode search, local timestamps, timezone formatting, metric/imperial recipes, and city/country naming conventions. Never machine-translate safety-critical medical, allergen or legal claims without review.

Price and accessibility policy: currency displayed in local tender; free events remain central; fees adjusted to local purchasing power rather than a flat global price; low-data mode, image compression, offline access to saved Plan details, and Android device coverage are launch-critical.

4. Product model and community flywheel

Objects: Person -> Circle -> Plan -> Participation -> Relationships -> Recurring Circle.

1. Member selects interests and optional city.
2. The app recommends relevant Circles and useful upcoming Plans.
3. A member joins a Plan or creates one from a template.
4. Hosts coordinate RSVPs, contributions, agenda and logistics within the app.
5. Participants attend; organizers optionally check them in.
6. Follow-up prompts invite feedback, photo sharing (consent-based), recurring plans and interest connections.

7. Successful hosts organize again; active members bring trusted friends; chapter density improves.

4.1 Product pillars

Circles: local and global groups by interest, food culture, household, budget, fitness, cooking skill or cause. Role-based moderation and visibility (public, approval-required, invite-only).

Plans: structured events and collaborative activities. Host chooses type (potluck, workshop, meetup, grocery order, food swap, volunteering, online class), visibility, age rules, RSVP capacity, agenda, contributions, reminders and safety settings.

Learn: member-created recipes and quick how-tos; live or offline teaching; bookmarked collections; beginner routes; affordable substitutions; contributions linked to real Plans.

Connect: member profiles, mutual-interest recommendations, respectful messaging rules, post-event connection requests, friend/mentor matching (not dating in MVP).

Coordinate: checklists, dish/ingredient sign-ups, shopping lists, poll-style group decisions and order-intent aggregation without platform custody of money in MVP.

4.2 Killer flow: the Community Plan

Example: Lagos cooking circle. A member creates “Plant-based Nigerian Sunday cook-along,” sets 10 seats, lists required ingredients and labels possible allergens, asks participants to bring an assigned item, enables a waitlist and invites a local Circle. Users RSVP, receive reminders and a private logistics chat. After the session, participants rate the activity, save the recipe and can join a recurring cooking Circle. A person in São Paulo can attend a separate online variant and share a plant-based Brazilian recipe exchange.

Plan types are structured; event discovery is not enough. The workflow must solve the unpleasant middle: capacity, uncertainty, coordination, cancellation, and continuity.

5. Business and monetization model

Revenue rule: community membership, basic connection, joining free Circles and attending free events must remain free. Monetize optional transactions and professional organizer tools, not social exclusion or sensitive personal data.

Stream	Timing	Hypothesis	Constraints
Paid in-person workshops/event ticketing	Phase 2	8-12% platform service fee on eligible ticket value, before processors/taxes	Regional payments, refunds, taxes, host verification, app-store rules
Host Pro subscription	Phase 2/3	Equivalent of US$8-20/month, localized; scheduling, insights, recurring Plans, additional co-host seats	Must clearly benefit serious organizers; digital purchases may require store billing
Brands / partner chapters	Phase 3	Paid verified partner profiles, local campaign partnerships or qualified leads	Clear sponsorship labels, no sale of member-sensitive data

Stream	Timing	Hypothesis	Constraints
Facilitated wholesale / group orders	Phase 3+	Supplier referral fee or small order margin	Consumer protection, delivery, liability, refunds, tax, local PSP support
Consumer Plus (optional)	Later only	Advanced tools, saved collections and conveniences	Never paywall basic belonging; test willingness to pay

Payment policy: in-person events and physical goods are generally treated differently by app-store rules than digital content, subscriptions and multi-attendee live online teaching. Classify each offering by the actual service and storefront before implementing checkout. [S9]

Regional processors: investigate providers that can onboard the legal entities and organizers in the chosen country. Paystack reports merchant support in Nigeria, Ghana, South Africa and Kenya and local channels including M-Pesa in Kenya; this does not automatically provide a global payout solution. [S10]

5.1 Illustrative monthly revenue scenario (not forecast)

This tests commercial sensitivity; every assumption must be validated.

Driver	Example assumption	Gross platform revenue
Ticket activity	1,000 tickets/month x US$12 average x 10% fee	US$1,200
Host Pro	200 paying hosts x US$12/month	US$2,400
Local partners	10 active partner plans x US$150/month	US$1,500
Total modeled gross revenue	**Before app-store fees, PSP charges, refunds, tax, operations and host acquisition**	**US$5,100**

This scenario shows why social apps need meaningful scale or higher-value recurring organizer revenue. Ticketing alone is unlikely to finance a heavily moderated international platform at low volume.

Unit economics dashboard: monthly gross profit contribution per participating member, ticket take net of processing and refunds, host acquisition cost, qualified organizer retention, partner acquisition cost, moderation cost per 1,000 active members and payback period. Do not optimize advertising CAC before organic retention is measured.

6. Go-to-market: solve the empty-community problem

6.1 Prelaunch (6-8 weeks)

1. Conduct 12-15 interviews per pilot city, ensuring different ages, cultural food interests, dietary preferences, incomes and organizer experience; run interviews in local languages where appropriate.
2. Recruit at least 8 prospective hosts in each initial launch city, including cooking teachers, nonprofits, community organizers and existing meetup leaders. Signed host commitments matter more than follower counts.
3. Run 2-3 offline events per city using lightweight manual tools, measure RSVP-to-attendance conversion, repeat participation and safety incidents.
4. Show high-fidelity mobile prototypes to 10 attendees and 5 hosts per city. Observe whether they can complete Plan coordination faster than WhatsApp + Eventbrite/Meetup.

5. Validate legal requirements for host monetization, consumer claims and regional payments. Secure community moderators before public launch.

6.2 Host-led launch

- Establish a **Founding Host** program: early verified organizer profile, free tools for a fixed period, training and help publishing first events; no promise of financial earnings.
- Recruit **Chapter Stewards** with public role expectations and clear moderation escalation; stewards are not automatically paid employees or platform legal representatives.
- Partner with established associations (e.g., Nigerian, East African, Brazilian and city-level plant-based organizations) where there is reciprocal benefit and explicit consent. Never scrape their members or claim endorsement.
- Seed 3-5 useful Plans each week per activated city, a mix of free meetups and free teaching; promote culturally relevant events, not generic photos.
- Make every attended Plan a respectful invitation loop: host invites members, members invite friends, post-event Circle gives a next action.

6.3 Content strategy

Create “teach what you know” challenges: affordable Nigerian soups adapted for vegan ingredients; Kenyan plant-forward staples; Brazilian feijoada alternatives; Caribbean cooking; low-cost seasonal dishes; allergen-aware party food. Invite chefs and culturally competent creators to co-create rather than centrally deciding what each region eats. Distinguish vegan food requirements from nutrition or medical advice.

6.4 Expansion gate

Open a new city when a local launch team has confirmed organizers and activity supply, event attendance quality is acceptable, and moderation support exists. Broad international marketing before city liquidity produces inactive local maps and poor retention.

7. Measurement and validation

North Star: monthly **Meaningful Community Participations (MCP)**: unique member-to-Plan participations during the month that have a completed outcome. In-person events count through organizer check-in or a mutually confirmed attendance method; online sessions through time-bounded verified attendance; shared orders through confirmed coordination completion. Prevent duplicate/self check-ins and report fraud separately. Avoid equating an RSVP with participation.

Metric	Definition	Pilot decision threshold (initial target; adjustable)
Activation 7d	New users who join a Circle AND RSVP/complete an agreed action in 7 days	>= 35%
First Plan attendance	Confirmed RSVP participants who actually attend	>= 60%
30-day repeat participation	Attendees completing another activity within 30 days	>= 25%
Host repeat rate	Hosts publishing >=2 Plans in 60 days	>= 40%
City liquidity	Median relevant available Plans/week for an active user	>= 3

Metric	Definition	Pilot decision threshold (initial target; adjustable)
Safety response	High-severity reports acted upon within internal risk-based SLA	>= 95%
Moderation load	Cases per 1,000 monthly active members, segmented by city	Establish baseline
Financial contribution	Net contribution by city after local support and PSP costs	Trend toward positive before scale

Targets are decision hypotheses, not externally benchmarked industry norms. Use cohort analysis by city, acquisition source, device, language, activity type, organizer and first-to-second participation. Monitor shortfalls in attendance or diversity, not just download growth.

8. Operational model and trust

8.1 Membership and safety

MVP is **18+ only** to avoid the separate safeguarding obligations and complex mixed-age interactions. Users must be able to use pseudonyms publicly, manually select a city, control profile visibility, request consent before direct contact, block users, report content or hosts and access clear community rules. Do not publicly expose attendance lists, exact home addresses, live location or sensitive diet identity without explicit user choices.

Public events should have safe venue guidance; private venue addresses should be shared only with approved attendees at an appropriate time. Organizers must provide clear attendee conduct rules, cancellation terms and food-allergen disclosures where meals are involved. The app cannot certify that community-provided foods are allergen-free.

High-severity reports (violence, credible threats, stalking or child-safety concerns) require rapid human review and escalation workflows; do not promise automated AI moderation is sufficient. Repeated no-shows, scams, discriminatory harassment and impersonation require proportional enforcement and appeals.

8.2 Country-by-country compliance

The EU GDPR and, where applicable, Digital Services Act; Brazil's LGPD; Nigeria's Data Protection Act 2023; Kenya's Data Protection Act 2019; and US state privacy laws can affect operations. Public content, private messages, transactions, transfers, data retention, age restrictions, and moderation require professional legal review. [S11] [S12] [S13] [S14]

Implement privacy-first architecture, consent logging, terms acceptance versioning, data export/deletion, auditable moderation, retention schedules, cross-border data-transfer assessments, abuse reporting and documented processor agreements. Do not automatically treat vegan/vegetarian identity as non-sensitive in every jurisdiction; dietary identity can reveal sensitive characteristics in some contexts.

9. Product and technology investment

Mobile: React Native + Expo + TypeScript, shared UI/design tokens and platform-native components, with direct on-device testing. Cross-platform source code is not the same as a webview or PWA. Use push notifications, secure credential storage, local offline caches and deep links; keep package size and mobile data demands controlled. Expo's SQLite supports persistent on-device storage, and its push system supports production app credentials. [S15]

Backend MVP: PostgreSQL/PostGIS, Supabase for authentication, storage and database services if team capacity favors it; dedicated TypeScript or Python service for Plan state changes, moderation, activity logs, search indexing, notifications and idempotent scheduling. Use server-enforced permissions and authorization—not UI-only checks. A vendor-neutral service boundary permits migration at scale.

Supporting web: landing pages, SEO for public Plans (only when explicitly public), host administration and staff moderation dashboard. The primary member product stays iOS and Android.

Indicative lean staffing, adjustable: product founder/designer (1), mobile engineers (2), backend engineer (1), QA engineer (fractional/1), community operations (1-2 across regions), trust & safety on-call coverage (outsourced or staffed), local host leads. Obtain bids and staffing estimates before budget commitment. Required work cannot be safely delivered by a single engineer plus an unstaffed public social network.

10. Phased roadmap and stage gates

Phase	Approximate window	Outcome	Gate to proceed
0. Discovery	Weeks 1-6	City interviews, prototype tests, first manual events, host commitments	Evidence of switching pain and organizer willingness
1. Private Alpha	Weeks 7-16	iOS/Android community foundation, Circles, Plans, chat, moderation	No critical safety defects; task completion benchmarks
2. Closed Beta	Months 5-7	2 cities, real recurring hosts, event participation measurement	Attendance, repeat use, acceptable moderation load
3. Global Beta	Months 8-11	Extend to up to 4 city chapters; worldwide online Circles	Cohort and host-repeat thresholds met
4. Monetization	Months 10-14	Approved paid in-person workshops, host tools and partner pilots	Tested economics and jurisdictional checkout
5. Expansion	Months 12-18+	Additional cities, languages, regional partners and group commerce pilots	Liquidity plus positive or improving contribution

Do not ship everything on day one. The critical minimum is safe identity + Circles + Plans + attendance + communication + repeat activity. Collaborative group orders can begin as no-payment coordination and progress to commerce only after member trust and supply operations are demonstrated.

11. Risk register

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Empty network outside cities	Users churn after sign-up	Worldwide online Circles; manual city opt-in; chapter launch gates
Host supply shortage	Too few activities	Founder-run events and partner organizers before user acquisition
Existing social products are "good enough"	Users do not switch	Observe comparative coordination tasks and event repeat rate

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Unsafe offline interactions	Serious personal harm and legal exposure	Attendee controls, location privacy, reporting, host training, staff escalation
Scams in shared purchases	Trust loss and liability	No custody of funds in MVP; clear non-payment intent, verified organizers
Global moderation costs	Unit economics worsen	Community rules, risk-based tooling, staffed queues, local experts
Cultural mismatch	Low relevance and reputation damage	Local advisors, creator-led content, multiple languages, local pricing
Country-specific legal complexity	Launch or payments delayed	Staged commerce and counsel review by jurisdiction
Weak connectivity	Exclusion, particularly on lower-end phones	Offline Plan details, lightweight images, retries and background sync
Food misinformation / allergy harm	Health and reputational risks	Clear disclosures, moderation policy, credible source pointers

12. Financial framework and founder decisions

Rather than presenting an invented TAM or ungrounded profitability forecast, use a bottom-up model per active city:

Active city members x monthly Plan participation rate x ticket purchase rate x average eligible ticket value x take rate + host subscriptions + paid partners = *gross platform revenue*. Subtract payment processing, app-store charges where applicable, refunds, customer support, moderation, creator/host incentives, cloud costs and local operations to arrive at contribution margin. Report country and currency independently before converting to a consolidated reference currency.

The founder must approve: product name after clearance; launch cities after interviews; whether to support Portuguese in initial release; host verification levels; policy for private gatherings and food handling; payment integration timing; legal-entity structure and support footprint; and 6-month funding envelope. These are unresolved choices—not implied completed decisions.

13. 30-day execution checklist

1. Interview at least 40 members and 15 active organizers across two African and two American candidate cities; record last event organized, tools used, cost and failure points.
2. Build a clickable mobile prototype of onboarding, Circle discovery, Plan creation, RSVP, contribution sign-up, in-app conversation and post-event follow-up.
3. Run at least 4 real community activities using manual coordination, with consent-based attendance tracking and post-event interviews.
4. Recruit initial Chapter Stewards and draft host standards, report categories, response SLAs and incident playbooks.
5. Validate English/Portuguese copy and low-end Android behavior with people in intended launch markets.
6. Test pricing with actual organizers and partners; do not use only stated interest as willingness to pay.
7. Use quantitative evidence to decide whether to fund the full mobile build and which cities launch first.

Sources and research links

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Document note: This is a product and business planning hypothesis, not an investment prospectus, market-size certification, legal opinion, or audited financial projection. Proposed prices, targets, phases and cities are decision inputs to validate.